LIBRARIANSHIP AS A PROFESSION

Meaning of a Profession

A profession is an occupation that requires specialised knowledge, formal education, professional training, and is guided by a code of ethics, with the main aim of serving society.

In simple terms, a profession is not just a job you do for money; it is a career based on expertise, standards, and responsibility to the public.

What Makes an Occupation a Profession

An occupation is regarded as a profession when it possesses the following characteristics:

1. Specialised Body of Knowledge

A profession has a unique and organised body of knowledge that is not common to everyone. This knowledge is developed through research, theory, and practice.

2. Formal Education and Training

Members of a profession must undergo formal education in recognised institutions such as universities or professional schools before practising.

3. Professional Association

Every profession has an organised body that regulates practice, protects members' interests, and promotes professional standards.

4. Code of Ethics

A profession operates under ethical rules that guide the behaviour and conduct of its members and ensure responsible service to society.

5. Service to Society

A profession exists primarily to serve the needs of society rather than personal gain alone.

6. Autonomy and Professional Judgement

Professionals are allowed to use their expert judgement in carrying out their duties without undue external control.

7. Continuous Professional Development

Members of a profession are expected to update their knowledge and skills regularly through training, research, and professional activities.

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How Librarianship Fits into a Profession

Librarianship fits perfectly into the definition of a profession because it meets all the recognised criteria:

1. Librarianship Has a Specialised Body of Knowledge

Librarianship is built on specialised knowledge areas such as:

1. Organisation of knowledge (cataloguing and classification)
2. Information retrieval
3. Reference and information services
4. Collection development
5. Digital libraries and information technology

This knowledge is taught as **Library and Information Science (LIS)**.

2. Librarianship Requires Formal Education and Training

To practise as a librarian, one must obtain formal qualifications such as:

1. Diploma in Library and Information Science
2. Bachelor of Library and Information Science (BLIS)
3. Master of Library and Information Science (MLIS)

This confirms librarianship as a learned profession.

3. Librarianship Has Professional Bodies

Librarianship is regulated by professional associations, for example:

1. **Nigerian Library Association (NLA)**
2. **Librarians' Registration Council of Nigeria (LRCN)**

These bodies regulate practice, set standards, and register professional librarians.

4. Librarianship Operates with a Code of Ethics

Librarians are guided by ethical principles such as:

1. Free and equal access to information
2. Confidentiality of users' information
3. Intellectual freedom
4. Professional integrity

These ethical rules guide librarians' conduct.

5. Librarianship Is Service-Oriented

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The primary aim of librarianship is to serve users' information needs, including students, researchers, teachers, and the general public.

6. Librarianship Requires Professional Judgement

Librarians use professional judgement in:

1. Selecting information resources
2. Organising information
3. Assisting users
4. Managing library services

7. Librarianship Encourages Continuous Learning

Librarians engage in:

Workshops and seminars

Conferences

Research and publications

ICT skill development

Conclusion

Librarianship is a profession because it possesses a specialised body of knowledge, requires formal education and training, is regulated by professional bodies, operates under a code of ethics, and is committed to serving society. Therefore, librarianship is not just an occupation but a recognised and respected profession.

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